

Bladder Management

Pets with spinal cord problems may be unable to urinate on their own, for a short time or permanently. An overfull bladder is uncomfortable, prone to **infection**, and can permanently **lose its tone** if stretched too long. Leaking urine in bed does not mean the bladder is emptying — it is often **overflow** from a full bladder. If you are not sure the bladder is being emptied, ask us.

Three ways to help your pet urinate

1. **Take them to their usual potty spots** regularly — familiar smells help them relax.
2. **Medications** we prescribe — some relax the muscles that hold urine in; others help the bladder squeeze.
3. **Manual bladder expression** — gently squeezing the bladder (below).

How to express the bladder

Find the bladder: feel the belly just in front of the hips, toward the back legs. A very full bladder sits further forward and feels like a water balloon.

1. **Position:** lay your pet on their side, or support them standing if they can.
2. **Hands:** place both hands flat on either side of the belly, fingers toward each other (like praying) around

the bladder. Try fingers pointing forward or backward to see which works better.

3. **Pressure:** press gently and steadily, slowly increasing the pressure evenly from both sides. Hold until the stream starts, then keep steady pressure until it stops.

Express **3–4 times a day** (or as directed). This takes practice — be patient with yourself and your pet.

Videos and detailed instructions: www.dodgerslist.com

When can I stop?

Good sign: your pet urinates on their own with a **strong, steady stream** — you may stop expressing (check with us first).

Still needs help: only dribbles urine, or does not produce a good stream within 12 hours.

Call us right away if

- Your pet seems **painful** when urinating or being expressed
- Urine is **dark, bloody** or **foul-smelling**
- You **cannot express** the bladder, or it stays large and firm
- No urine for 12 hours or more